battalions equipped with the latest T-55 tanks, a MiG-21 F-13 [NATO-designation Fishbed] fighter wing of forty aircraft, thirty-three Ilyushin-28 [NATO-designation Beagle] navy torpedo bombers, and eighteen Sopka [NATO designation SSC-2b Samlet] coastal-defence cruise missiles (in addition to six already committed).[77] There were also 144 S-75 Dvina (NATO designation SA-2 Guideline) surface-to-air missile launchers with 576 missiles, able to shoot down a U-2 at a height of 70,000ft.

From the outset, it was intended to equip Soviet forces with nuclear weapons to defeat an invasion. Two air force regiments with sixteen mobile launchers, each with five Meteor FKR-1 cruise missiles (NATO designation SSC-2a Salish), possessed a total of eighty missiles. Their variable yield warheads were in the five to twelve kiloton range. The Meteors had a range of 90-125 miles, which meant they could just about reach US territory. One regiment was to target Guantánamo Bay. At no point did US intelligence realise the Soviets had deployed the Meteors. The crates in which they were transported were misidentified as those used for Sopka coastal defence missiles (which were not nuclear-capable).

In the 1960 presidential election, Kennedy used communist Cuba as a stick with which to beat the Republicans. The Soviet military build-up during 1962 caused growing political concern in the US and provided Republicans with a stick to beat him. Congressional elections were due on 6 November. Missiles in Cuba might well mean the end of his hopes for re-election in 1964. Republicans in Congress, such as Homer Capehart, Strom Thurmond and Barry Goldwater were vociferous in their condemnations, while Kenneth Keating, Senator for New York, provided specific allegations. On 31 August 1962 Keating alleged the presence of Soviet troops and reports of missile bases. On 10 October he told the Senate that construction had begun on ‘at least half a dozen launching sites for intermediate-range tactical missiles.’[78] This was four days before the fateful U-2 overflight over San Cristóbal.

On 4 September the White House issued a statement warning that ‘the gravest issues would arise’ if Moscow deployed ‘offensive ground to ground missiles’ or other significant offensive capabilities. In a news conference on 13 September the President stated that if Cuba became an